

LAPTOPS FOR WORLD DOMINATION

Laptops have matured a lot over the years and they are continuing to get better at allowing us to do what we do best. But we're not there yet, and the best is yet to come.

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INTRODUCTION

Technology as a whole has evolved a lot over the last couple of decades. There's been a monumental change across multiple categories but they all stand pale in comparison to the absolute revolution in portable computing. You don't have to turn back the clock to the '80s to understand how laptops have evolved. Even if you go back to, say, 2001, you'll see that only a ridiculously small number of laptops were available on the market. Our very first edition of Digit magazine, which came out in June 2001, also mentioned only one laptop in the A-List column - The Zenith 21A. That's because only a handful of people had that kind of moolah to splurge on futuristic machines. A classic case of first-generation products, I say.

REWIND BACK TO THE '80S

'IBM 5100 Portable Computer' is one of the prime examples of what portable computing was back in the day when it all started. With an IBM PALM processor clocked at 1.9 MHz and 16-64 KiB RAM, the IBM behemoth weighed 24 kg and it was the size of a small suitcase. Portable, sure, but that designation is obsolete by today's standards.

A few more "portable" computers that followed after that also belonged to the same breed. Truly portable

laptops that are somewhat similar to the current form-factor weren't a thing at least until the '90s. These machines were still extremely bulky and were mostly meant to be used on a desk. Not to mention, they were also ultra-expensive oddities, in my book.

The Apple PowerBook 500 series that came out in 1994 was considered to be a big leap mainly because they were the first to feature a capacitive-touch trackpad. The 500 series machines were also the first one with 16-bit stereo sound and built-in ethernet networking. The PowerBook 520 model with all the goodies came in at a sweet \$2,270, which roughly translates to about ₹1.65 lakh.



Credit: Wikipedia



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These laptops that came out in the late '90s and early 2000s aren't impressive for a kid looking to buy a new laptop in 2021. But it's important to celebrate them as much as we can because they pioneered the idea of various categories that we have today.

A lot of you probably know the Alienware Area-51M, the beast of a gaming laptop built to truly replace your desktop setup. But the Alienware Area-51M was born back in 2002 and it was the first-ever laptop that was specifically designed for gaming. The idea of buying a dedicated portable for gaming was something that was unheard of, which is also why it was considered to be a ground-breaking laptop.

It didn't come cheap but there were people who were willing to shell out upwards of ₹2.15 lakh for a 3.06 GHz Pentium 4 processor, 1 GB